



STATUS REPORT

Sao Tome and Principe — digital transformation and data governance status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Public Administration is the only one of São Tomé and Príncipe's 16 governance sub-categories in the Ibrahim Index to fall in Africa's bottom ten, at 44.6 out of 100 in 2023, 41st of 54 and down 3.2 points over 2014-2023, even as its Effective Administration indicator rose 5.1 points to 53.6 — a striking weakness in a country whose Overall Governance score of 59.2 ranks 12th of 54 African states, up 0.7 points over the decade but down 0.9 over the most recent five years (2023). The same profile makes Foundations for Economic Opportunity, which covers public administration, the business environment, infrastructure and the rural economy, the weakest category at 43.4 out of 100, 41st of 54 and up only 0.3 points over 2014-2023, against a wider picture in which the country scores above the African average on 64 of its 96 indicators.

The written policy base is thin and largely predates the current programme. The 2020 National Strategy for Digital Governance sets out nine thematic axes and proposes an authentication platform with single sign-on tied to digital identity, and a single government portal at GOV.ST; a National Framework for Interoperability followed on the same government site in 2021, the two together forming the published governance documentation for the data exchange programme, which has no public dashboard or real-time reporting. More recently the government has approved a public-administration reform strategy whose essential pillar is electronic governance, aimed at rationalising processes, cutting bureaucracy and costs and promoting equity of access to public services (June 2025), and the central bank's fintech sandbox sits under the National Financial Inclusion Strategy rather than standing as a one-off initiative (June 2025).

Much of the rest is still being written: the national data strategy remains in draft, the identity strategy and modernisation roadmap is an unmet project target, and the national cybersecurity strategy awaits approval by the Council of Ministers (2025). Separately, the country held a national Data Governance Capacity Building Workshop on 9-10 July 2026 on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework domestically, run by the D4D Hub with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet.

Legislation and regulation

São Tomé and Príncipe has no aggregated identification document law in force, an absence the World Bank's September 2025 mission flagged as urgent because it could constrain the data collection the new digital identity depends on. Civil identification still rests on colonial-era Decree 251/71, updated by Decree 09/2018 on digitisation, which the World Bank assesses as outdated and scattered with gaps for digital identity, no dedicated digital ID regulation having been enacted (2024).

Other digital legislation is part-finished. An electronic signature law has been passed, while an Electronic Communications Law and a Law on Regulatory Authorities have been approved by the Council of Ministers and await the National Assembly (2025). A law establishing automatic and permanent voter registration entered into force in 2026, formalising data sharing between the civil registry directorate and the National Electoral Commission. A national interoperability framework gives public authorities a legal basis for sharing data but has not been implemented (2024).

The settled parts of the statute book are data protection, consumer protection and payments. Law No. 03/2016, promulgated on 10 May 2016 and modelled on the EU's Directive 95/46/EC, applies to personal data processed by public and private bodies, with Law No. 07/2017 establishing the National Data Protection Agency as its enforcement body. It obliges controllers to notify the agency at least eight days before processing begins but imposes no post-breach notification duty, so no mandatory data-breach notification applies to payment or other personal data. Consumer Protection Law 9/2017 covers disclosure duties, unfair contract terms and redress across sectors, with no payment-specific consumer regime enacted (2021). The national payment system runs on Decree-Laws 01/2017 and 06/2017, which establish the operator SPOUT, NAP 01/2012 on bank card issuance and use, and NAP 09/2019 with Decree-Law 16/2019 on electronic funds transfers and payment service providers, and the central bank's own Organic Law, Law 03/2025, creates an audit committee over its accounts.

Data protection

On 1 June 2026 Macau's Personal Data Protection Bureau signed a cooperation memorandum with São Tomé and Príncipe's ANPDP, authorised by Macau's Chief Executive Sam Hou Fai, covering cross-border data flows, supervision of artificial intelligence, public awareness, training and joint studies. The São Toméan delegation presented on the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence, and also visited Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association (June 2026). A year earlier the same agency was in Lisbon, where a cooperation visit to Portugal's CNPD identified disinformation on social media, rising digital violence and videosurveillance as the two regulators' shared concerns, alongside the need to train data subjects, particularly children and young people (June 2025). Macau frames this outreach as strengthening the chain of cooperation between China and the Portuguese-speaking countries on data security and privacy.

The Agência Nacional de Proteção de Dados Pessoais is also active at home. It worked with Facebook in January 2025 to remove fake profiles impersonating public figures, and, chaired by José Manuel Costa Alegre, it supervises the interconnection between the civil registry and electoral databases, which it will assess once the linkage has been inspected (April 2026).

What the law gives citizens is narrower than what it promises. Law No. 03/2016 grants rights of access, correction and deletion, but there is no online portal or digital mechanism through which a person can view their own identity data, and access requires an in-person request to the civil registry directorate or the agency (2024). Articles 19 and 20 restrict transfers of personal data outside the national territory unless the destination offers an adequate level of protection, with no sector-specific localisation requirement standing in place of that general rule, and the absence of any duty to notify a breach after the fact leaves the regime weighted towards prior notification of processing rather than incident response.

Regional collaboration

São Tomé and Príncipe is a third country to West Africa's data regime: ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 on Personal Data Protection confines itself by its Article 3(3) to processing carried out in a UEMOA or an ECOWAS member state, and being a Supplementary Act of the Authority it binds those states directly without transposition.

The practical consequence sits in [Article 36](#), under which personal data may leave an ECOWAS member state for a non-member country only where that country offers an adequate level of protection and only on prior notification of the transferring state's data protection authority.

Membership of neither ECOWAS nor the West African Economic and Monetary Union puts the country outside the region's digital machinery entirely: the ECOWAS identity, customs-transit, roaming and data-protection instruments and the BCEAO's regional clearing, settlement and instant-payment rails carry no obligation for it and give it no access (September 2026).

Its collaboration runs on other axes. The data protection agency is a [founding member of the Rede Lusófona de Proteção de Dados](#), set up in 2024 with the authorities of Portugal, Angola, Brazil and Cabo Verde, Brazil holding the presidency and Portugal the permanent secretariat (June 2025), a network [Macau's data protection bureau](#) joined in [April 2026](#) — putting the Portuguese-language regulators of Europe, Africa, Latin America and China in one room. Bilateral work with Cabo Verde extends beyond the regulator: the two countries [signed protocols in January 2024 to computerise the justice sector](#). The country's own regional bloc supplies a legal floor rather than infrastructure, with ECCAS free movement and establishment rights giving migrants a basis for access to financial services (2025), while cross-border payments still [rely on banks' SWIFT access through the central bank](#) rather than any regional instant payment link. At continental level the country [worked on domestic adoption of the African Union Data Policy Framework](#) at a July 2026 national workshop.

Standards

The standards in use are inherited rather than chosen. The customs administration is [preparing to move to ASYFIVE](#), the United Nations successor to the ASYCUDA system used in more than 103 countries (January 2026), and the passport issuing system launched in April 2026 uses a biographic-page technique from Portugal's Imprensa Nacional-Casa da Moeda.

São Tomé and Príncipe is building its foundational identity system on open standards: a system integrator, Ooru, was contracted in September 2025 to design a new bilhete de identidade as a digital ID on the open-source MOSIP platform, jointly led by INIC and the civil registry directorate DGRN. Working prototypes of the surrounding stack — a verifiable credentials infrastructure, a data-exchange and interoperability platform, a citizen portal and app, and an e-signature service — were built to open standards with the source code made available to the government (September 2025).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

São Tomé and Príncipe has Africa's freest civic and digital space and a shrinking role for the public in making policy. Its civil society space scores 91.2 out of 100 in the 2023 Ibrahim Index, first of 54 African states and unchanged over the decade, while Deliberative & Participatory Governance — how far policy is made through consultation — scores 61.5, 22nd of 54 and down 4.0 points over 2014-2023. On speech the country ranks near the top of the continent, at 93.1 out of 100 for Freedom of Expression & Belief, second of 54, and 70.4 for Media Freedom, sixth of 54, both slightly down over the decade, and public perception of freedom of speech rose 14.2 points over 2014-2023 to 86.8, third of 54 and among the country's ten most improved indicators. The online dimension matches it: the index's Digital Freedom indicator, covering online censorship, government internet shutdowns and surveillance, scores the country 88.9 out of 100 in 2023, first of 54 African states and essentially unchanged over the decade.

The constraint is not what citizens may say but what they can get hold of and act on. The country scores poorly on the [accessibility of public records and online government services](#), better but still low on [disclosure of budgets, asset declarations and official documents](#), and its [representation of rural populations in decisions that affect them](#) is among its most deteriorated measures of the decade (2023).

Electoral participation is where the digital and the deliberative meet. The [reform of the electoral system was designed to answer the recommendations of the European Union observation missions of 2021 and 2022](#), and the [new registration system was declared ready in February 2026 for the general elections held that July and September](#). Where the public sphere itself has come under pressure, the response has been regulatory rather than restrictive: the data protection agency's [removal of impersonating profiles from Facebook in January 2025](#) is the clearest instance.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

No memorandum of understanding or comparable digital-sector agreement involving Sao Tome and Principe had been concluded as at September 2026.

New investments

Sao Tome and Principe takes in [the highest official development assistance per head of any African state, USD 233.7 \(2023\)](#), first of 54 on a population of 0.2 million and a GDP of USD 0.6 billion; the digital share of that flow is small and comes almost wholly from the development banks.

The [World Bank's Digital Sao Tome and Principe project \(P177158\)](#), a USD 22 million grant approved in June 2022 and running to 2027, is the largest single live external commitment to the country's digital economy, funding connectivity, digital public services and digital skills. The older of the two is the African Development Bank's [Payment System and Financial Inclusion Infrastructure Project](#), XDR 2.4 million as a grant on a window running from 2017 to 2027, for internationalising the national payment system, securing lending and developing electronic payment instruments, and still active on that window. The Bank returned to the same system in 2023 with a [loan agreement to add real-time gross settlement and automated clearing house functions to the national switch](#).

Smaller external support sits outside the banks. The [trade single window and ASYFIVE deployment carries UNDP technical and financial backing](#) (January 2026), and the [EU-funded electoral system reform project, delivered through Portuguese Cooperation, closed in September 2025](#). Identity modernisation is externally funded as well, through a [World Bank IDA grant and the Gates Foundation by way of MOSIP](#), against a registration directorate whose own card-fee revenue does not sustain it.

Two multilateral commitments name the country directly. The regional digital integration and regional identification programmes financing its West African neighbours run through ECOWAS and WAEMU, to which it does not belong, so none of them reaches it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Príncipe is off the fixed network: [the island's average fixed broadband speed stood at 0.00 Mbps against 8.3 Mbps on São Tomé in September 2025](#), the supply contract for its submarine cable was still unsigned, and none of the 70 schools targeted for new broadband access had yet benefited.

Satellite has begun filling part of the gap. [Starlink activated service in the country in December 2025](#), and the free national identity card campaign now reaches remote localities on a Starlink link and a portable generator supplied by [the PReSE electoral reform project](#) (January 2026).

On the main island the incumbent CST launched commercial 4G in August 2023 across 102 antennas in 34 locations and inaugurated a further antenna at Água Izé in Cantagalo district in March 2026, ending a prolonged period of network instability there. An Electronic Communications Law and a Law on Regulatory Authorities have cleared the Council of Ministers but await the National Assembly (2025).

Signal is not the constraint: 96% of the population was covered by an LTE or WiMAX network in 2024, while 59.1% used the internet that year, against 58.7% in 2023, and mobile connections stood at about 170,000 in 2025, equal to 71.4% of a population of some 238,000.

The long trend is real but starts low. Infrastructure is the worst-scoring of the country's 16 IIAG sub-categories at 34.4 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, up 3.2 points over 2014-2023; mobile communications rose 30.2 points to 65.9, the third most improved of 96 indicators, and internet and computers rose 14.0 points to 38.1, still below 40. The floor is physical delivery rather than telecommunications: shipping and postal networks score 1.6 out of 100, 52nd of 54 and the country's lowest indicator of all.

None of it has reached the public's judgement. Perception of infrastructure fell 29.0 points over 2014-2023 to 36.0 out of 100 — the third most deteriorated indicator in the country's profile, and a fall recorded while the measured score was rising.

Data Storage

The government's only data centre is in the wrong place: the Centro Nacional de Dados, run by INIC since around 2019, is flood-vulnerable and is being assessed for replacement by a resilient centre or migration to cloud under World Bank financing, while the national data strategy for 2025-2030 remains in draft and unadopted (2025).

There is no commercial alternative onshore — the country records no commercial data centres (2024) — so critical systems sit abroad. The civil registration system SIGA is hosted in Portugal at the University of Aveiro, a foreign infrastructure dependency the World Bank flags as a business continuity risk (2024).

Both ends of the choice are now being pursued at once. A World Bank mission recommended in September 2025 that the digital identity system move to a TIER III data centre or to cloud hosting, and in May 2026 the project's fiduciary agency AFAP tendered for data-centre servers and disaster recovery capacity for that system.

Where the data may go is governed by the general regime rather than a localisation rule: Law No. 3/2016 restricts transfers of personal data outside the national territory unless the destination offers an adequate level of protection, with no sector-specific requirement layered on top.

Energy

Connection is not the binding constraint on power; supply is. Load shedding runs to between three and seven hours a day (2024), even though electricity access reached about 84% of the population that year.

Access itself is comparatively even by regional standards, at 81.9% of the urban population against 69.6% of the rural population in 2023, a gap of 12.3 percentage points. Generation remains almost entirely thermal — renewables supply about 3% of electricity, and an off-grid policy is active with a mini-grid rollout planned (2024).

The index reading tracks the same picture: access to energy scored 40.8 out of 100 in 2023, 27th of 54 African states, up 6.2 points over 2014-2023.

The cost of unreliable power lands on the systems built on top of it. A 2023 assessment found that many schools, disproportionately rural ones, cannot use the national SIGE education management system because they lack electricity, computers or reliable internet, leaving rural primary schools on largely paper record keeping.

Technical Capacity

The country's whole supply of technical people comes from one institution. The Universidade de São Tomé e Príncipe, through its Faculty of Sciences and Technologies, is effectively the country's only provider of ICT and STEM degrees, including computer engineering, information technology and electrical or energy engineering.

Public administration is the state's weakest arm and it is getting weaker: it is the only one of the 16 IIAG sub-categories in Africa's bottom ten, scoring 44.6 out of 100 in 2023, 41st of 54 and down 3.2 points over 2014-2023, even as its effective administration indicator rose 5.1 points to 53.6. The wider category it sits in, foundations for economic opportunity, scores 43.4 out of 100, 41st of 54 and up only 0.3 points over the same decade.

That thinness shows in how core systems are run. The DGRN relies on external vendors for its core systems and hosts civil registration abroad (2024), and identity modernisation is funded from outside — a World Bank IDA grant of over USD 16.25 million and the Gates Foundation through MOSIP — with the registry resource-constrained and card fee revenue insufficient to sustain it.

Where capability does exist it has been built programme by programme. The health ministry runs DHIS2 nationally, with tablets and computers issued to facilities and staff trained to enter data at the point of care for named vertical programmes including HIV, TB, malaria and routine immunisation (2023), and in January 2026 UNODC delivered computers and secure data storage equipment to the Polícia Judiciária headquarters for criminal investigation work.

Cybersecurity

The country has a cybersecurity strategy on paper and almost nothing standing behind it: the National Cybersecurity Strategy and Action Plan 2024-2028 has been drafted but awaits Council of Ministers approval, the national incident response team CERT-STP is still being established with staff recruitment and tool procurement only beginning in late 2025, and no independent security review of the digital identity system has been completed.

The index reading is consistent with that. São Tomé and Príncipe scored 20.44 out of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, in the index's evolving band, up from 15.64 in 2020.

Nor does anyone have to say when something goes wrong. Law No. 3/2016 requires controllers to notify the data protection agency at least eight days before processing begins but imposes no post-breach notification duty, so a compromise of payment or other personal data carries no reporting obligation.

DPI

Data Exchange

The one link between two government databases carrying live national business is the electoral one: a platform built by the University of Aveiro under the EU- and Portuguese-funded electoral reform project, connecting the SIGA civil register and the identity card system to the electoral database, was substantially built and awaiting legal review in September 2025 and went into service when automatic and permanent voter registration was inaugurated at the end of April 2026, ending the repeated manual censuses. Nothing equivalent exists at the centre of government: the World Bank's Digital STP project recorded no operational interoperability solution as of September 2025, against a target of June 2027, with no government system connected to one.

Institutional access to civil registry data instead runs through the Legimon platform over a secure VPN, supporting basic queries rather than system-to-system exchange, and the join between civil registration and civil identification is thin: enrolment reuses SIGA data by QR code or name search, there is no automatic update, and no unique identification number ties the two together. The other working cross-sector connection links the Unified Social

Registry to the health ministry's DHIS2 individual tracker for case management, a sectoral arrangement rather than a route into any national platform, and the national retail payment system is not integrated with any government-wide exchange for payments to people or businesses.

What is being built was shown to a World Bank mission in September 2025 as working prototypes of a verifiable credentials infrastructure, a data-exchange and interoperability layer, a citizen portal and app and an electronic signature service, all on open standards with the source code handed to the government; the documented scope adds digital forms but carries no analytics or fraud-detection capability. The Guiché Único business register, which runs on fragmented systems with total dependence on paper, is being redesigned as one of the first uses of that platform. Separately, an integrated port and external-trade single window with the ASYFIVE customs platform is in preparation, intended to bring the ports and airports authorities, the central bank, the Treasury and the investment agency onto one traceable system.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A system integrator, Ooru, was contracted in September 2025 to design a new foundational bilhete de identidade as a digital ID on the open-source MOSIP platform, and the system was still a pilot in 2026. The card in circulation is a physical document with no electronic elements, and identity records remain a mix of paper and digital because most legacy card holders were never entered in the digital database. Passports moved faster: a modernised issuance system, SEP 2.0, launched in April 2026 under a four-year contract with Portugal's state mint.

Coverage is the binding constraint. Around 90,000 people were in the digital identity database in October 2021 and roughly 98,000 after the 8,070 first-time cards issued in 2022, fewer than half of eligible residents against a population of some 219,000 to 240,000. Civil registration is compulsory within 30 days of birth but the card itself is optional in practice, and many adults use the cédula pessoal drawn from their birth certificate instead; issuance or renewal normally costs STN 100, rising to STN 160 for very urgent processing. Two campaigns have pushed against that: a DGRN mobile brigade issuing the card free to every citizen reaching majority, working through Ilhéu das Rolas and Porto Alegre from January 2026, and cards for São Toméans in Portugal, available for collection at the Lisbon embassy from June 2026. The system is open only to nationals and the diaspora, with no route for refugees, asylum seekers or permanent residents, while the card or cédula is required to open a bank account, activate a SIM, reach basic public health services and join the flagship Vulnerable Families Program.

The modernisation is almost entirely externally funded, through a World Bank IDA grant of over USD 16.25 million and the Gates Foundation via MOSIP, with card fee revenue insufficient for sustainability; the financing project was 36% disbursed by September 2025. Know-your-customer checks are still manual, with electronic KYC proposed but not available, and publication of an identity strategy and modernisation roadmap, a project target for May 2027, had not happened as of September 2025.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank launched the country's first fintech sandbox in June 2025, structured as a five-phase incubator rather than a standing authorisation regime, with reducing the volume of cash in the economy an explicit objective.

It starts from a very small base. Digital payment use is very low, with financial inclusion at around 24% on central bank survey data (2023); merchant acceptance rested on 138 POS devices in December 2021, all run by SPOUT, which holds exclusive rights to operate terminals; and person-to-person transfers ran through banking channels, with no mobile money operator in the market at that date. The IIAG's access to banking services score fell 6.0 points over 2014-2023 to 20.0 out of 100 in 2023, 27th of 54 African states.

The plumbing is functional but dated. The Dobra24 interbank ATM and card network has run since October 2011 and is being modernised towards a national switch with disaster recovery and, later, real-time gross settlement; it was rebuilt on a system supplied by Portugal's SIBS from 2021, and the African Development Bank signed a USD 3.2 million loan in 2023 for the switch upgrade. The central bank both regulates and operates: it runs the SICOI clearing platform, holds national SWIFT access and owns 61% of SPOUT, and cross-border payments depend on that SWIFT access rather than any regional instant-payment link — the country sits outside the WAEMU rails the BCEAO operates, including the PI-SPI instant payment service that opened in September 2025.

Government payments have barely moved: civil service salaries are distributed through printed payment lists submitted to banks, and a plan to route them through the finance ministry, the central bank and SPOUT is proposed but not operational (2023). The exceptions are narrow: the Ke-Non social protection system has used a bank-based module through BISTP since 2023 to pay conditional cash transfers to more than 10,000 vulnerable families, the one substantial digital channel from state to citizen, and tourism fees have been collected by digital card since August 2025. Some taxes can be paid by electronically initiated bank transfer, though collection remains mostly cash or cheque.

Registries

The electoral roll used for the 2026 elections was the first ever derived automatically from civil-registry data rather than from a separate enrolment exercise, and it inherited the registry's own omissions: 1,860 people of voting age were missing from the July 2026 lists through a process failure. The roll stood at 146,510 electors at the end of July 2026, against 142,191 at the presidential poll of 19 July, with a public inspection and update window running 1-8 August 2026.

The roll grew by 4,319 electors between the 19 July 2026 presidential poll and the end of that month, a rise of about 3.0 per cent.

The civil register beneath it is stronger. The DGRN implemented the SIGA registry management system by 2018, enabling digital registration of births, deaths, marriages and divorces nationwide, and trained registry staff and midwives now enter births directly into an electronic database at maternities, with paper forms being phased out (2026). Birth registration reached 98.6% of the population and about 99% of children under one in the 2019 MICS, and the IIAG's civil registration score rose 37.5 points over 2014-2023 to 62.5 out of 100, 24th of 54 African states in 2023 and the second most improved of its indicators.

Other registers lag well behind. The Unified Social Registry, established under Decree-Law 16/2018 and run by the social protection directorate on the Ke-Non system, covered about 12,000 families and 52,808 individuals after the second recertification and expansion reported in June 2026, up from 8,000 families. Land is the weakest: the Integrated Property Registration System has catalogued roughly 131,000 real-estate and vehicle records, but installation of the software is incomplete after a contractual dispute with the original developer and land administration remains largely paper-based (2025). The Guiché Único business register runs on outdated and fragmented systems with total dependence on paper, and a modern replacement was demonstrated as a working prototype in September 2025. The tax directorate is the outlier, maintaining a taxpayer identification register with online registration and filing, with electronic invoicing required under the VAT Code since 2020 and an electronic tax mailbox mandated by a 2023 decree.

Sectoral management information systems

The newest sectoral system is clinical rather than administrative: a teleconsultation service launched in June 2026 with the Brazilian state of Piauí's digital health programme provides remote medical consultations in the underserved district of Caué. Beneath it, the health ministry has deployed DHIS2 nationally, issuing tablets and

computers to facilities and training staff to enter data at the point of care for vertical programmes including HIV, TB, malaria and routine immunisation, though rural health posts and primary centres still record routine registration, consultations and prescriptions on paper, with aggregates passed upward for entry at district level (2023). Social protection runs on the Ke-Non system, adopted in May 2023 on the openIMIS platform, holding the Unified Social Registry and linked to the national civil registry for client identification.

Education has had a management information system since 2018, operated by the ministry for school records and not connected to any government data exchange; a World Bank-supported programme equipped a majority of primary schools with computers and connectivity and trained head teachers to enter attendance, enrolment and administrative data at school level, but many schools, disproportionately rural ones, cannot use it for want of electricity, computers or reliable internet.

Justice and security are earlier still. São Tomé and Príncipe and Cabo Verde signed protocols in January 2024 to computerise the justice sector; an integrated case management system contracted in December 2022 covers police, prosecution, judiciary and prison services within the city of São Tomé in its first phase, and the national police is running its own computerisation programme. UNODC delivered computers and secure data storage to the Polícia Judiciária headquarters in January 2026. The systems the state uses to raise and manage money went the other way over the decade: tax and revenue mobilisation fell 11.3 points to 34.7 out of 100 and budgetary and financial management fell 19.4 points to 43.1 in the 2023 IIAG, 40th and 42nd of 54 African states.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

INIC launched a beta version of the Portal do Cidadão, the single citizen portal, in March 2026, eighteen years after the institute was founded and six years after the national digital governance strategy proposed a single government portal at GOV.ST. The starting point is low: the country scored around 0.22 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, ranking 154th and placing it in the index's low group.

Individual services have gone digital ahead of the portal. The embassy in Portugal has issued civil-registry documents directly since April 2025 — birth certificates, the polycarbonate identity card, criminal record certificates and certificates of capacity to marry — drawing on the SIGA register from abroad. A job-matching platform at [emprego.st](#), launched in 2022 with ILO support and run by the labour ministry, lets seekers and employers register, and the tax directorate's online filing is the most established transactional channel. Against that, electors correcting their address or polling station in the August 2026 update window could do so only in person or over WhatsApp, a consumer messaging app standing in for a citizen service interface.

The largest piece in preparation is in trade: an integrated port single window, external-trade single window and ASYFIVE customs platform, supported technically and financially by UNDP, intended to cut clearance times and raise revenue, with ASYFIVE not yet running anywhere in Africa.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Sub-national government has no presence in Sao Tome and Principe's data exchange work: no district or regional system was taking part as at 2025. Where district administration does handle data it acts as a relay rather than an origin, health facilities keeping manual registers whose paper aggregates are entered into DHIS2 at district level — the district is the first point at which a rural record becomes digital, and it is the last point at which anything sub-national is done with it.

Rural digital data capture

Sao Tome and Principe [created a digital agricultural marketing platform in October 2025](#), built with FAO support to put producers directly in touch with consumers, and the Ministry of Agriculture [opened field collection for the third General Agricultural Census in July 2025](#). Those are the two places where rural information is gathered into a system rather than a filing cabinet.

Routine capture at the point of service is still paper. A 2023 WHO assessment of rural health posts and primary health centres found [registration, consultations and prescriptions written into manual registers and patient cards](#), with paper aggregates carried upward and keyed into DHIS2 at district level rather than entered at the facility. An assessment the same year for the Global Partnership for Education found that [many schools, disproportionately rural ones, cannot use the national SIGE education management system](#) for want of electricity, computers or reliable internet, or because staff find it hard to use, leaving rural primary schools on predominantly paper records.

What stands behind that is physical. Rural households [reach electricity at a materially lower rate than urban ones](#) (2023), and the national energy compact rests near-term rural supply on [an off-grid policy and a planned mini-grid rollout](#). Reach is thinner again off the main island, where [the Principe submarine cable supply contract was still unsigned and the schools targeted for new broadband had yet to benefit](#) (September 2025). Where capture has to happen regardless, the equipment travels with it: the free identity card brigade [works remote localities off-grid on a satellite link and a portable generator](#) (January 2026), and a teleconsultation service opened in [the underserved district of Caue](#) (June 2026).

The governance side has moved the wrong way. The Ibrahim Index scores the [Rural Economy sub-category at 49.3 out of 100 in 2023, 37th of 54 African states and 5.0 points below its 2014 level](#); its Rural Representation and Participation indicator, drawn from IFAD data on how far rural populations are represented in decisions that affect them, [fell 20.6 points over the same decade to 49.0, the fifth most deteriorated of the country's 96 indicators](#).

Technology

AI

The state is not building artificial intelligence into its own systems. The data-exchange platform under construction with World Bank support [covered verifiable credentials infrastructure, an interoperability and data-exchange layer, a citizen portal and mobile app, an electronic signature service and digital forms as at September 2025](#), with no artificial intelligence or analytics capability for fraud detection, data quality or prediction in its documented scope.

Artificial intelligence has reached Sao Tome and Principe as a supervision question rather than an industrial one: on 1 June 2026 Macau's Personal Data Protection Bureau [signed a cooperation memorandum with the national data protection authority, the ANPDP](#), covering cross-border data flows, the supervision of artificial intelligence, public awareness, training and joint studies. The same month a Sao Tomean delegation in Macau [presented the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence](#), and visited Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association.

ICT Industry

No ICT sector policy or industry strategy had been adopted in Sao Tome and Principe as at September 2026.

Innovation ecosystem

The country's only general business incubator is not a technology incubator: REINA [opened a central facility in the capital in 2022](#) with Ministry of Youth and UNDP support, and its work spans agribusiness, tourism and hospitality rather than technology.

The nearest thing to a technology-specific programme sits at the central bank, whose [first fintech sandbox](#) opened in June 2025 and is structured as a five-phase incubator running from capacity-building through product design and testing to results, rather than as a standing authorisation regime that a firm could enter and leave on its own initiative.

Sao Tome and Principe is [not among the 133 economies covered by the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024](#), so no innovation score or rank is published for the country, and comparisons that use the index as their frame leave it out entirely.

Capacity

Literacy

Education is one of the country's stronger showings in African governance measurement: [education completion reached 69.6 out of 100 in the 2023 Ibrahim Index, tenth of 54 African states and 19.9 points above its 2014 level, with enrolment up 11.3 points to 59.4 and twelfth of 54.](#)

Getting those pupils online has moved more slowly. [CST and the Ministry of Education have been working to connect schools to the internet, larger schools first \(January 2025\), but none of the schools targeted for new broadband access under the World Bank's digital project had yet benefited \(September 2025\), and Príncipe was still without a working submarine cable contract or measurable fixed broadband speed at that date. School-level data handling is further ahead than school-level connectivity: the Ministry of Education has \[run an education management information system for school records since 2018\]\(#\), and a \[World Bank-supported programme has equipped much of the primary system with computers and connectivity and trained head teachers and administrative staff to enter attendance, enrolment and administrative data themselves \\(2023\\).\]\(#\)](#)

Training and skills

The whole domestic supply of ICT and STEM graduates comes from one place: the [Universidade de São Tomé e Príncipe](#), founded in 2014, teaches computer engineering, information technology and electrical and energy engineering through its Faculty of Sciences and Technologies, and no second institution offers such degrees.

Beyond the university, skills work is externally funded and mostly aimed at officials rather than students. Digital skills are one of the three components of the [World Bank's Digital São Tomé and Príncipe project, which runs to 2027 alongside its connectivity and digital public services work. The most recent set-piece was a national Data Governance Capacity Building Workshop on 9–10 July 2026 on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework domestically, run by the D4D Hub with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet. The data protection authority has been building its own bench through bilateral contact: a June 2025 visit to Portugal's CNPD put the training of data subjects, and of children and young people in particular, on the shared agenda alongside disinformation and video surveillance, and in June 2026 a delegation presented the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence in Macau, also calling on Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association.](#)

Research institutions

Higher-level technical work rests on a single institution: the [Universidade de São Tomé e Príncipe's Faculty of Sciences and Technologies, established with the university in 2014, is the only body in the country working at degree level in computer engineering, information technology and electrical and energy engineering.](#)

Inclusion

Access to services

Public services reach social groups unevenly and a decade has not shifted it: the country scores **41.0 out of 100 for equal access to public services**, **26th of 54 African states** and **half a point better than in 2014** (2023), while equal socioeconomic opportunity rose 12.4 points to 52.0.

Most of what the state and the banks provide runs through one document. **The national identity card or cedula pessoal is required to open a bank account, activate a SIM, use basic public health services and join assistance programmes**, a requirement resting on the 1971 civil identification law, and the **digital identity register still holds a minority of residents** (2022) though birth registration is close to universal. The card is **not free to issue or renew**, and the system is open only to nationals and the Santomean diaspora, with no route in for refugees, asylum seekers or permanent residents (2023).

Two routes have opened around cost and distance. A **DGRN mobile brigade has been issuing the card free to citizens reaching majority in remote localities including Ilhéu das Rolas** (January 2026), working off-grid over a satellite link, and the **embassy in Lisbon has issued civil-registry documents directly from the SIGA register since April 2025**, with cards from the "BI para Todos os São-Tomenses" campaign ready for collection there in June 2026.

Financial access binds anything built over payments: **account ownership and banking reach rank among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators** (2023), **digital payment use is very low** (2023) and no mobile money operator was in the market as at December 2021. Migrants have a legal basis for financial access through ECCAS free movement rights, but **know-your-customer demands for proof of address and employment shut out informal workers**, nothing accommodates refugees or asylum seekers, and a recommendation to issue consular identity cards remains outstanding (2025).

Digital delivery has come through narrow channels: **conditional cash transfers to vulnerable families through the Ke-Non social protection system** (2024), **remote medical consultations in the underserved district of Caué** (2026), and, for the electoral roll, **a messaging app standing in for a citizen service interface** (July 2026).

Digital divides

Satellite broadband arrived in December 2025 at a price that settles who it is for: **Starlink's Residential plan launched at STN 1,700 a month, about US\$79.5, with a Lite plan at about US\$60.8**, on top of a one-off charge for the hardware.

At those launch prices a Residential subscription takes a large share of average monthly output per head, which makes satellite service a complement to the incumbent's fixed and mobile network rather than a substitute for most households.

The sharpest divide is between the two islands. **Príncipe's submarine cable supply contract was still unsigned in September 2025**, the smaller island had no working fixed broadband to speak of, and none of the schools targeted for new connections had yet benefited. On the main island the incumbent has gone on extending reach — **a 35th antenna at Água Izé, in Cantagalo district, was inaugurated in March 2026** after a prolonged spell of network instability there — while **rural households remain further from mains electricity than urban ones** (2023), which sets a floor under anything connectivity alone can close.

Access to networks has improved faster than the distribution of what the state delivers over them. The [2024 IIAG country profile](#) records mobile communications among São Tomé and Príncipe's most improved indicators of the 2014-2023 decade, and internet and computer access rising from a low base, while its [measure of equal access to public services](#) barely moved across the same ten years.

Data

National statistics

Two of the country's longest-standing statistical gaps closed within a year of each other: [enumeration for the housing and population census finished in December 2024](#) under a US\$3 million component of the World Bank's Digital STP project, which also funds an updated master sampling frame, and [the Ministry of Agriculture and the National Statistics Institute began collecting data for the third General Agricultural Census in July 2025](#). Both filled holes the World Bank had recorded: as at 2023 the Statistical Performance Indicators showed [a population census held within the previous twenty years but no agricultural census and no economic or business census in that period](#).

The survey record thins the same way. The same indicators register [no agricultural survey, no business survey and no labour force survey in the past ten years](#), against two health surveys and one household survey (2023) — so employment, farm output and enterprise activity are all measured, when they are measured at all, from something other than a recent national instrument. The banded scores locate the problem precisely: [50-69% on data use, data services and data products but only 20-49% on data sources and on data infrastructure](#) (2023). What the system does with what it has outperforms what it is given to work with.

Capacity is nonetheless climbing. The IIAG's measure of whether the state can produce and publish reliable statistics [rose 7.1 points over 2014-2023 to 49.2 out of 100, 26th of 54 African states](#). The residue shows up as absence in the international indices that draw on national reporting: [the 2024 IIAG carries no data for São Tomé and Príncipe on four of its 96 indicators — Education Quality, Human Resources in Education, Rural Market Access and Enforcement of Environmental Policies](#) (2023), and the country falls outside the economies covered by the [Global Innovation Index 2024](#) altogether. Administrative sources are the stronger flank, with [birth registration close to universal](#) and an [electoral roll republished with updated figures through the 2026 cycle](#).

Open data

Publishing records and being able to get hold of them have come apart. The IIAG's measure of whether budgets, asset declarations and official documents are published [rose 17.7 points over 2014-2023 to 28.7 out of 100, among São Tomé and Príncipe's ten most improved indicators](#), while its companion measure of whether citizens can actually obtain official records and use online government services [gained 0.8 points over the same decade to 20.5, 39th of 54 African states and one of the country's ten worst-scoring indicators](#) (2023). More is being put out; almost nothing has changed about reaching it.

The 2024 Open Data Inventory sets a low ceiling even where the country does best. Its strongest categories are economic: [6 out of 10 on the coverage and openness of balance of payments, government finance, international trade and money and banking statistics, 4.5 on national accounts and price statistics and 3 on labour statistics](#). Across every social and environmental category the score sits between 3 and 5 — [4.5 for population, health facilities and reproductive health, 3.5 for education outcomes, health outcomes and gender, 3 for agriculture and natural resources](#). Nothing in the assessment reaches the upper half of the scale, which is consistent with the [World Bank's finding that data sources and data infrastructure are the system's weakest pillars](#) (2023).

The most reliable open publishing runs through the central bank rather than a government portal. The [Banco Central de São Tomé e Príncipe posts payment system statistics covering internet banking from 2014, SICOI interbank clearing from 2013 and card payment operations from 2011](#), each series carrying its own update date. On the governance side the published material is the rulebook rather than the data: the [National Framework for Interoperability](#) sits on the INIC website with no accompanying public reporting on what moves through the data exchange it governs.

Use of satellite data

[Starlink switched on service in São Tomé and Príncipe in December 2025](#), putting satellite broadband on retail sale in the islands. The activation was one of a batch across the continent in the same window, [alongside Somalia, Chad, Lesotho, Guinea-Bissau and Congo](#), so it reflects a regional rollout schedule rather than anything particular to the country's market.

Entry was smoothed politically well before it happened: the United States chargé d'affaires, James Story, [publicly backed the company's investment plans in February 2025 after meeting the President](#).

The entry price is set at the hardware. Kits launched at [STN 5,500 for the Standard and STN 4,400 for the Mini](#) — about US\$257 and US\$206 at December 2025 rates — before the [monthly Residential and Lite subscriptions](#) that run on top of them.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States chargé d'affaires in São Tomé and Príncipe, James Story, [came out publicly for Starlink's entry to the country in February 2025](#) after meeting the President, putting the mission's weight behind one American operator in a market small enough that a single connectivity supplier can shape it. [Service was switched on in December 2025](#), in the same window as activations in Somalia, Chad, Lesotho, Guinea-Bissau and Congo, which places the São Toméan opening inside a continental rollout rather than a bilateral arrangement.

American presence moved the other way at the same time. Washington [closed its long-running Voice of America relay station in the country in 2025](#). Taken together the two moves describe the shape of United States engagement as it now stands: a commercial satellite subscription sold direct to households, in place of a state broadcasting installation with a physical footprint, staff and a standing obligation to keep transmitting. Nothing in the Starlink arrangement gives the government a lever over the service, and no hyperscaler has any other announced presence on the islands.

China activities

Macau, not Beijing, is China's channel into São Tomé and Príncipe's data governance: Macau's data protection bureau [describes its agreements with São Tomé and Príncipe and Cabo Verde as strengthening "the chain of cooperation between China and the Portuguese-speaking countries in the areas of data security and protection of personal privacy"](#) (August 2026). Macau [casts itself as a "precision interlocutor" between the mainland and the Portuguese-speaking countries](#), running its outreach through the China–Portuguese-speaking Countries Forum (May 2026) — a framing that lets a Chinese engagement arrive in São Tomé in Portuguese, through an institution with no visible Beijing branding.

The relationship is now formal. Macau's bureau [signed a cooperation memorandum with the ANPDP in June 2026](#), and a [separate anti-money-laundering track was announced in August 2026](#), framed and announced apart from the data protection work rather than bundled into one package. Macau also [joined the Rede Lusófona de Proteção de](#)

[Dados in April 2026](#), which places it inside the same Portuguese-language regulatory network the ANPDP helped found – so the Chinese channel reaches São Tomé's regulator both bilaterally and through the body Portugal and Brazil run. What is being cultivated is a supervisory authority rather than a network or a data centre. That is a cheaper investment than infrastructure and a more durable one: the rules a small regulator learns, and the peers it learns them from, outlast any particular contract.

EU activities

The European Union's [Electoral System Reform Project \(PReSE\) closed in September 2025](#), a €500,000 programme delivered through Camões / Portuguese Cooperation with the voter-registration platform built by the University of Aveiro. It was [designed to answer the recommendations of the EU election observation missions of 2021 and 2022](#), which is how European conditionality reached the country's registry systems: through the electoral roll, not through a digital strategy. The frame outlasted the funding – the [registration reform behind the 2026 roll still sits under PReSE \(July 2026\)](#), and the project's [interoperability platform linking civil registration and the identity card to the roll was reported all but finished in September 2025](#).

European engagement here is mostly Portuguese engagement. The civil registration system SIGA is [hosted in Portugal at the University of Aveiro](#), a foreign infrastructure dependency the World Bank flags as a [business continuity risk](#) (2024); the Dobra24 interbank platform [runs on a system supplied by Portugal's SIBS](#); and the data protection authority is a [founding member of the Lusophone network established in 2024](#), with Portugal holding the [permanent secretariat](#). Brussels-level activity is thinner and more recent: Team Europe's D4D Hub [ran a national data governance workshop on 9–10 July 2026](#) on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework, with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet. The exposure this creates is not political but operational: the country's foundational registry, its payment switch and its electoral platform all depend on Portuguese institutions, and the machinery would not survive their withdrawal.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based company had an announced digital or data infrastructure engagement in São Tomé and Príncipe as at September 2026.

India activities

India had no announced digital cooperation, investment or technology programme in São Tomé and Príncipe as at September 2026.

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